Q+A

SOMETHING'S COOKING

Huma Qureshi appears as cookbook author Tarla Dalal in the eponymous biopic



Q. Tarla Dalal was one of the first cooks Indians saw on TV. What's your memory of her?

I feel she normalised being on TV for the average Indian woman. She was this cute, affable lady, who had a vibe to her. I remember her cookbooks being in the house and my mother referring to them, whether it was to make Chinese, Italian or mango ice-cream. There's a scene in the film when Tarla gets the copy of her first cookbook. I was like "Oh my god, we had this book", and this is me now. I feel the little me manifested it.

Q. Your father has run a successful restaurant in Delhi for decades. How much of your relationship with food seeped into playing Tarla Dalal?

Sharing food is such an intimate act of love and has the ability to create bonds. We all remember sharing our tiffin or a drink and being told that *pyaar badhta hai* [love grows]. Of course, the film is a biopic and charts how she became an entrepreneur, but it is also about how she changed the lives of so many women and the impact her recipes had.

Q. How did you interpret Tarla Dalal as a character?

The idea was not to mimic or make a caricature of her. I especially didn't want to do a stereotypical Gujarati character. The idea was to keep it real, to imbibe her essence and spirit. I saw a lot of her cooking videos and noticed that like many homemakers, she multitasked, her mind, speech and body moving in different directions. She used her hands a lot, her sentences were not finished and she'd mispronounce words too.

Q. With releases like *Maharani* and *Monica, O My Darling*, is this one of the best spells of your life professionally?

It has taken a long time to get here. I had to make mistakes and figure it out. In the initial years, I was worried about what people would think. Now I am having fun. I am obsessed with creating real, living, breathing three-dimensional women on screen who connect with people. It is a good place to be in.

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

with Suhani Singh